

CXL

Google Ads Search Experiments

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THE JOURNEY OF THIS COURSE

Objective 1

Google Ads Experiment Tool

Experiment Types, Settings,
and Interpreting Results.



Objective 2

Recommended Search Experiments to Run

Examples of Experiments that
will almost always help you.



Objective 3

Performance Max Experiments

How to run experiments on
Performance Max campaign types.

Lesson 1: Google Ads Experiment Tool

Course Objective 1: Things to Know Before Making an Experiment

LESSON OBJECTIVES

1. Review how the Experiments function works.
2. Understand what will prohibit an Experiment from happening.

WHY USE EXPERIMENTS?

Splits your traffic and budget for you to test elements against each other

1. Easier to manage
2. More rigor/more accurate split than trying to do it manually
3. Automatically see results and stat sig easily

HOW EXPERIMENTS WORK

Experiments create a copy of the Campaign you choose.

You make the changes in the Experiment version, and Google splits the traffic between the two, measuring the difference in results.

However, not every Campaign is eligible.

**Here are instances
where an
Experiment cannot
be created.**

"NO GO" ON EXPERIMENT CREATION

- Shared budgets
- Campaign already is running an Experiment
- Campaign type cannot be Shopping or App
- Unsupported/discontinued ad types will error (text ads, ETAs, DSAs)

LESSON RECAP

1. Experiments automate A/B testing, with differences between two Campaigns you specify.
2. There are a few exceptions that Experiments won't work for.

Lesson 2: The Google Ads Experiment Tool

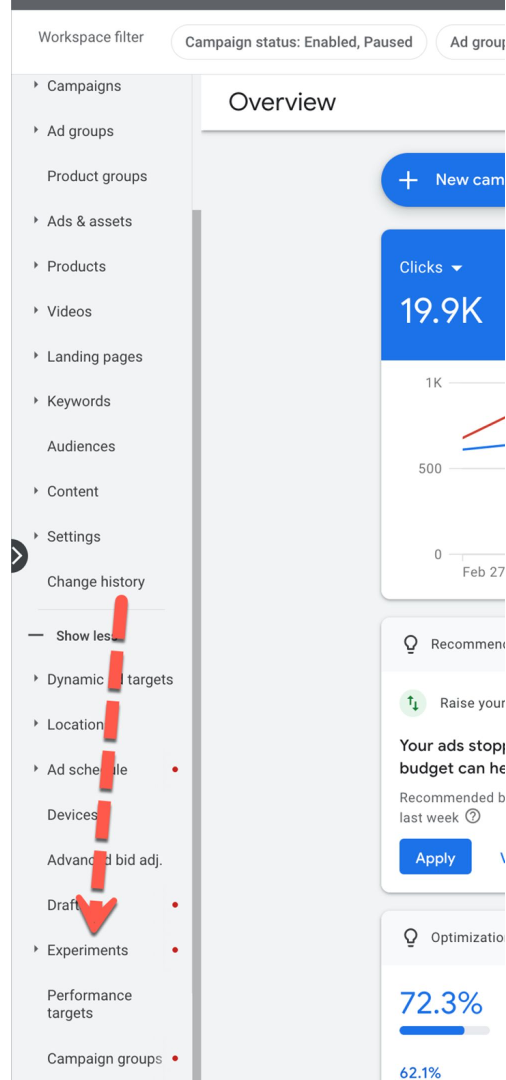
Course Objective 2: The Experiments Interface

LESSON OBJECTIVES

1. Where to locate the Experiments section.
2. Basic overview of the Experiment results.

WHERE TO FIND IT

- The Experiments interface is in the left-hand margin
- Please note, Google has rolled out an updated interface that not everyone has yet. Experiments is still in the left margin



EXPERIMENT SUB-MENU

This will open a panel of your Experiments on the right, with a sub-menu in the left margin on the Experiment types.

If you have the updated interface, there will be no sub-menu there - check out the next slide for how you find these options.

Workspace filter Campaign status: Enabled, Paused Ad group status: Enabled, Paused Add filter

► Landing pages
► Keywords
Audiences
► Content
► Settings
Change history
— Show less
► Dynamic ad targets
► Locations
► Ad schedule
Devices
Advanced bid adj.
Drafts
▼ Experiments

All experiments
Ad variations
Custom experiments
Performance Max experiments
Video experiments

Performance targets
Campaign groups

All experiments

Recommended Experiments

Bid more efficiently with Maximize conversion value using a target ROAS +0.6%

Get more conversion value at a similar ROAS with a value-based bidding strategy

Create Experiment

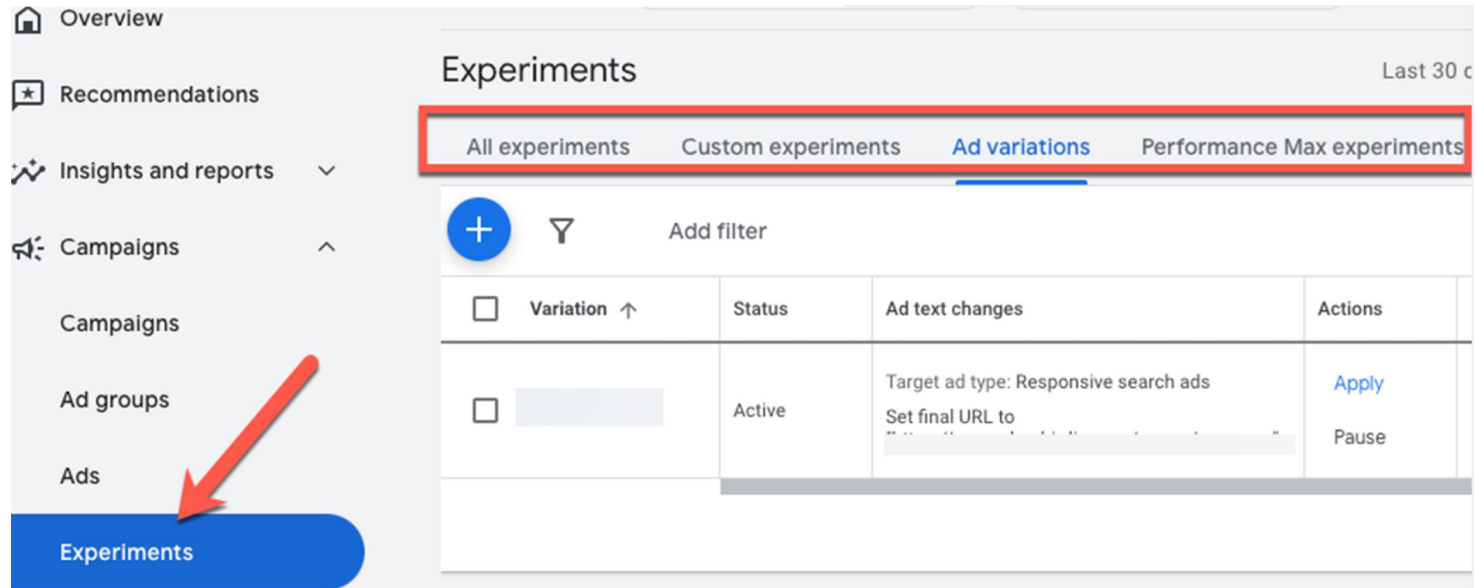
+ 1

Status: Setup, Creating..., + 4 more Add filter

Name	Type	Status
	Custom search	In progress
	Custom search	Setup
	Custom search	Setup

Reporting is not real-time. Time zone for all dates and times: (GMT-04:00) Eastern Time. Some inventory may be provided through third party intermediaries.

EXPERIMENT SUB-MENU: NEW VIEW



The screenshot displays the Google Ads interface with the 'Experiments' sub-menu selected in the left-hand navigation bar. A red arrow points to the 'Experiments' button in this menu. The main content area is titled 'Experiments' and shows a tabbed interface with four tabs: 'All experiments', 'Custom experiments', 'Ad variations' (which is selected and underlined), and 'Performance Max experiments'. A red rectangle highlights these tabs. Below the tabs, there is a '+', a funnel icon, and the text 'Add filter'. A table lists the experiments, with the first one being 'Active' and showing 'Target ad type: Responsive search ads' and 'Set final URL to'. The table has columns for 'Variation', 'Status', 'Ad text changes', and 'Actions'.

Overview

Recommendations

Insights and reports

Campaigns

Campaigns

Ad groups

Ads

Experiments

Experiments

Last 30 d

All experiments Custom experiments Ad variations Performance Max experiments

+ Add filter

☐ Variation ↑	Status	Ad text changes	Actions
☐	Active	Target ad type: Responsive search ads Set final URL to	Apply Pause

EXPERIMENT

SUB-MENU: NEW VIEW

- As you launch Experiments, they will appear in a list
- Clicking on the name will take you to the Experiment and its details

☐	Name
☐	Brand : ROAS
☐	Brand ROAS Test
☐	Target ROAS experiment - [SHO] Best Sellers
☐	CPC Bids
☐	Brand CPC Test
☐	CPA Bids
☐	CPA Bid Test 8/22
☐	CPA Bid
☐	ROAS Bidding Test
☐	Other Products Test
☐	EXC : IS Test
☐	Test ROAS Sale

EXPERIMENT VIEW: RUNNING

Status

In progress

Brand  ROAS is still in progress

Current results

Conv. value / cost

-15%

Inconclusive results

Performance comparison: Mar 25, 2023 – No end date ?

Apply Experiment

End Experiment

EXPERIMENT VIEW: RUNNING

In progress Brand ROAS is still in progress Conv. value / cost -15% Inconclusive results								
Performance comparison: Mar 25, 2023 – No end date Apply ExperimentEnd Experiment								
Mar 25 – Apr 18, 2023	ColumnsExpand							
Arm	Campaign	Cost	↓ Avg. CPC	Conversions	Cost / conv.	Conv. value / cost	Clicks	CTR
Base	Brand ROAS	\$3,495.99	\$1.42	296.69	\$11.78	8.28	2,458	40.77%
Trial	Brand ROAS	\$5,654.31	\$2.39	416.29	\$13.58	7.05	2,370	41.37%
Difference		+\$2,158.32	+\$0.96	+119.60	+\$1.80	-1.22	-88	+0.60%
^ Difference (%)		+62%	+68%	+40%	+15%	-15%	-4%	+1%
95% confidence interval								

STATISTICAL SIGNIFICANCE

Mar 25 - Apr 18, 2023									Columns	Expand
Arm	Campaign	Cost	↓ Avg. CPC	Conversions	Cost / conv.	Conv. value / cost	Clicks	CTR		
Base	freelance.org	\$3,495.99	\$1.42	296.69	\$11.78	8.28	2,458	40.77%		
Trial	freelance.org	\$5,654.31	\$2.39	416.29	\$13.58	7.05	2,370	41.37%		
Difference ⓘ		+\$2,158.32	+\$0.96	+119.60	+\$1.80	-1.22	-88	+0.60%		
^ Difference (%) ⓘ		+62%	+68%	+40%	+15%	-15%	-4%	+1%		
95% confidence interval ⓘ		[+51% , +73%] Statistically significant	[+59% , +77%] Statistically significant	[+6% , +75%] Statistically significant	[-10% , +40%] Inconclusive results	[-38% , +8%] Inconclusive results	[-10% , +3%] Inconclusive results	[-3% , +6%] Inconclusive results		

MAKE A DECISION RIGHT THERE

In progress

Brand  ROAS is still in progress

Conv. value / cost

-15%

Inconclusive results

Performance comparison: Mar 25, 2023 – No end date ?

[Apply Experiment](#)

[End Experiment](#)

LESSON RECAP

1. Experiments features a sub-menu based on the types of Experiments you can run.
2. Clicking into the Experiment will show you its current status, learnings, metrics, and stat sig calculation.
3. You can let it keep running, apply the changes from the Experiment campaign, or end the Experiment early.

Lesson 3: Ad Variation

Course Objective 2: Setting Up and Using Experiments

Experiments

LESSON OBJECTIVES

1. What Ad Variation Experiments do.
2. What you'll most often use them for.
3. How to set them up and launch them.

AD VARIATION EXPERIMENTS

- Change the URL you drive traffic to (ie, landing page testing)
- Add or pin text elements to test
- Find and replace text elements you want to test

The screenshot shows the 'Select ads' section of the Google Ads interface. It includes options for 'Campaigns' (All campaigns), 'Target ad type' (Responsive search ads), and a 'Filter ads' dropdown menu. The dropdown menu is open, showing a list of elements to filter: Headlines, Descriptions, Headlines and descriptions, Path 1, Path 2, Paths, Final URL, and Final mobile URL. A blue 'Create' button is visible at the bottom left.

1 Select ads

Campaigns

☐ All campaigns

☒ [] :t ✎

Target ad type

Responsive search ads

^ Filter ads

Headlines

Descriptions

Headlines and descriptions

Path 1

Path 2

Paths

Final URL

Final mobile URL

Create

AD VARIATION EXPERIMENTS

Name your test (I usually call it what I'm testing, like "New landing page" or something easily identifiable).

Choose how you want to split the traffic to the new version, and how long you want it to run.



Create variation

3

Set variation details

Variation name*

Start date

Apr 12, 2023 ▼

End date



None



May 12, 2023 ▼

Experiment split ?

50%

AD VARIATION EXPERIMENTS

Once your Experiment launches, you can access it in the Ad variations sections to see its results.

☐ Variation ↑	Status	Ad text changes	Actions	Affected ads	Clicks	Impr.	
☐ Compare LP	Active	Target ad type: Responsive search ads Set final URL to	Apply Pause	2	618 +3% [-11%, +18%]	1,578 +0% [-9%, +9%]	+3%

LESSON RECAP

1. The simplest Experiment type is Ad Variations.
2. Due to the default now being Dynamic Response Ads, Google auto-tests copy pretty efficiently.
3. You cannot test different landing pages with RSAs, so you'll use Experiments for this most frequently.
4. Setup guides you through what you want to test, finding and replacing elements, and setting up your traffic split to launch.

Lesson 4: Custom Experiments

Course Objective 2: Setting Up and Using Custom Experiments

LESSON

OBJECTIVES

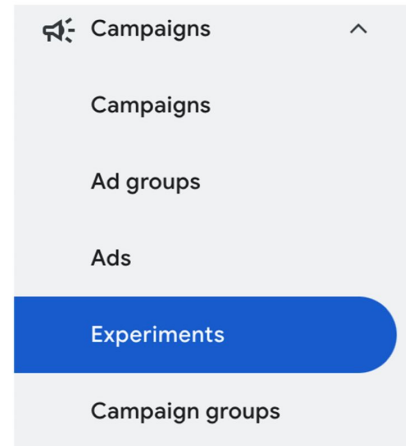
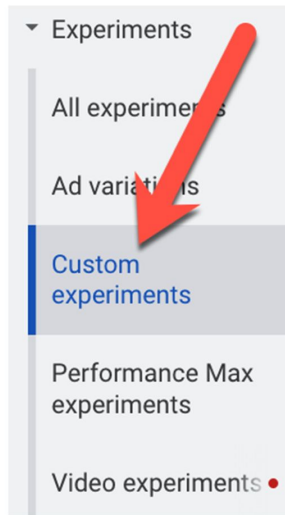
1. How custom Experiments work.
2. Where the options exist and how to set them up.
3. Effective tests you can consider running for almost any campaign.

CUSTOM EXPERIMENTS

Unlike Ad Variations, which limit you to just tweaking and testing your ads, Custom Experiments expand your options.

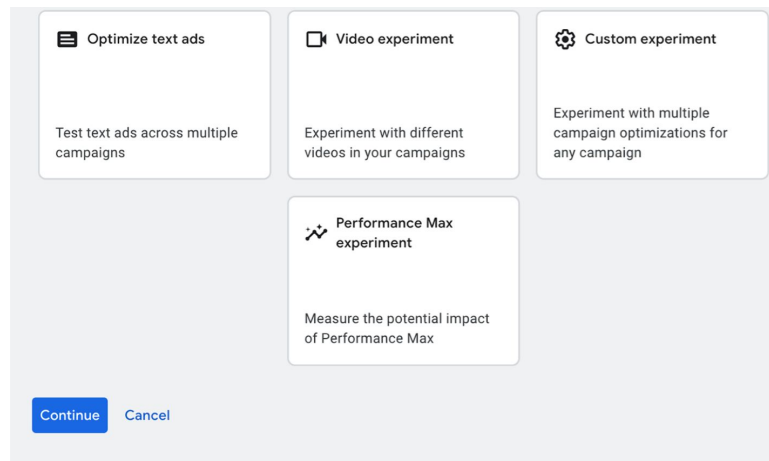
You can test everything from Campaign settings to keywords.

On the left is the standard view, on the right is the Upgraded view Google is rolling out.



CUSTOM EXPERIMENTS

When you choose custom, you'll see the other options, but continue on with "Custom Experiment".



CUSTOM EXPERIMENTS

The lesson will take you through using Search, but once you see how this works, you can easily apply the principles to other Campaign types.

Campaign type

☐ Display

☒ Search

☐ Video

CUSTOM EXPERIMENTS

Name your Experiment. This name will appear in the list of your Experiments.

Then choose the campaign that will continue to run as your control.

Google will start a copy of it where we'll make the changes we want to test.

Type: Custom experiment

Campaign type: Search

Experiment name

Experiment name

Description (optional)

Campaigns

Base campaign
Select a campaign you want to experiment with

CUSTOM EXPERIMENTS

This new Trial campaign will show in your list of Campaigns when you look at your account.

You can specify some text that will be added to the Experiment Campaign name. I would suggest noting what's being tested. For example, let's say your existing campaign uses Target CPA, and your Experiment will test Target ROAs. Put "Target ROAS" as the suffix.

Trial campaign

We'll create a copy of the campaign selected above in the next step, to make the necessary changes for this experiment

Suffix for the treatment name:

CUSTOM EXPERIMENTS

When you hit Save and Continue, you may get this message:

One or more campaigns in this experiment use deprecated ad types that can no longer be created. Please remove the deprecated ads or choose other non-trial campaigns.

Remember: if you have non-RSA ad types, you now must delete them in order to duplicate a campaign into an Experiment.

CUSTOM EXPERIMENTS

The next page will look like a typical view of a Campaign. Anything you touch or change now is being done ONLY in your Trial/Experiment campaign. You'll see at the top where you are in the process.

Back to
 All campaigns

Experiment
 ROAS Example

Campaigns (0)
Select a campaign

 Set up

 Make changes

 Schedule

Type: Custom search Changes made: None [Schedule](#)

START WITH THE QUESTION

Sometimes testing can feel overwhelming, because there are so many things you can test. This can especially be true with Custom Experiments.

An effective test answers a question, one way or the other. So start by asking a question:

- Does target CPA or target ROAS bidding work better?
- Does targeting by country, or by state work better?
- Are my results better filtering by best performing audience segments only?
- What happens to cost if I Optimize to acquiring new customers?

CUSTOM EXPERIMENTS

Trying to test too many things at once will usually teach you nothing.
Start with highest-impact items first:

- Bidding types
- Filtering Audience types
- Testing broad match vs. phrase/exact setups

LESSON RECAP

1. Custom Experiments let you change any aspect of an existing Base campaign.
2. The Trial and Base Campaigns are run simultaneously, so you can see the performance differences in the two.
3. Experiments can answer many questions, but you should create them with one main question to answer. You can always launch subsequent Experiments to answer other questions.

Lesson 5: Custom Experiments: Bidding

Course Objective 2: Setting Up and Using Custom Experiences

LESSON OBJECTIVES

1. Case study of running a bid experiment
2. How to look at results
3. How you can make decisions, even if you don't quite reach stat sig.

TESTING BIDDING TYPES

Bit types can play a major part in achieving different results. Here's an example of a running Experiment for this – it's almost always worthwhile!

- Well-known apparel brand
- Both DTC and also carried in department stores
- Brand defense is a focus - very competitive niche

The test:

- Tested tCPA versus Manual bidding previously. tCPA won.
- Now testing tCPA versus tROAS.

TESTING BIDDING TYPES

First, we see we've reached stat sig on the CPCs, meaning Google is confident this pattern would hold.

Base = tCPA

Trial = tROAS

tROAS is coming in higher, so the key is:
does it produce higher revenue to justify it?

Arm	Campaign	↓ Avg. CPC
Base		\$1.23
Trial		\$1.80
Difference 		+\$0.57
^ Difference (%) 		+46%
95% confidence interval 		[+40% , +52%] Statistically significant

TESTING BIDDING TYPES

Moving on, we also see it's driving much more in volume when tROAS is used – also in stat sig territory.

Arm	Conversions
Base	465.75
Trial	601.98
Difference ?	+136.24
^ Difference (%) ?	+29%
95% confidence interval ?	[+4% , +55%] Statistically significant

TESTING BIDDING TYPES

And finally, the ultimate question we wanted to know:
is it more efficient for ROAS?

Unfortunately, the results are not stat sig yet.

Early on, it looks like ROAS wins for both that
and CPA.

Arm	Cost / conv.	Conv. value / cost
Base	\$11.70	7.39
Trial	\$11.42	7.69
Difference ?	-\$0.29	+0.30
^ Difference (%) ?	-2%	+4%
95% confidence interval ?	[-21% , +16%] Inconclusive results	[-23% , +31%] Inconclusive results

WHAT DO YOU DO?

Wait for the test to send, and see if CPA/ROAS hit stag sig.

If they don't, you actually have informative data anyway!

tROAS is driving more volume. Even if the CPA/ROAS still winds up in the same ballpark at tCPA, you may already have a winner you can apply and use moving forward.

LESSON RECAP

1. Bid Experiments are almost always worthwhile to run as an Experiment.
2. Evaluate all the metrics for learnings, and not just the one you're specifically testing.
3. Don't be afraid to make a call without stat sig if all indicators seem to push to a good conclusion.

Lesson 6: Custom Experiments: Audiences

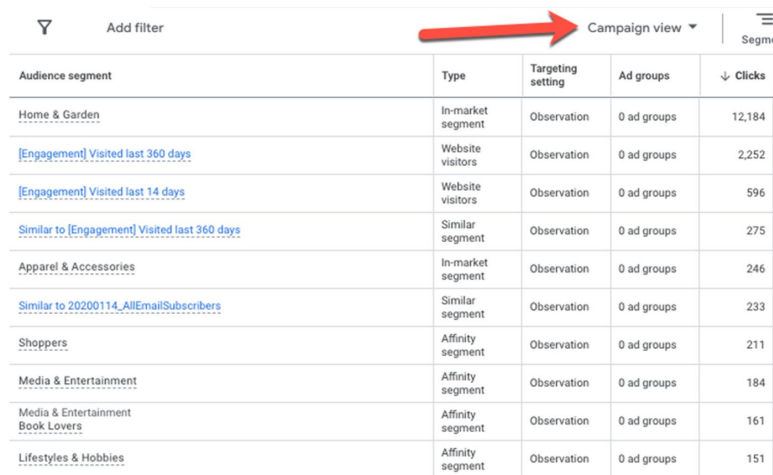
Course Objective 2: Setting Up and Using Custom Experiences

LESSON OBJECTIVES

1. Quick overview of Audiences in Google Ads.
2. How to set up an Experiment testing Audiences.

WHAT ARE GOOGLE AUDIENCES?

- Google has pre-made audience segments you can apply to your campaigns or ad groups
- You can also add your own, like website visitors
- These can be done as Observation (just gathering data) or as targeting (your ads only show to those audiences)



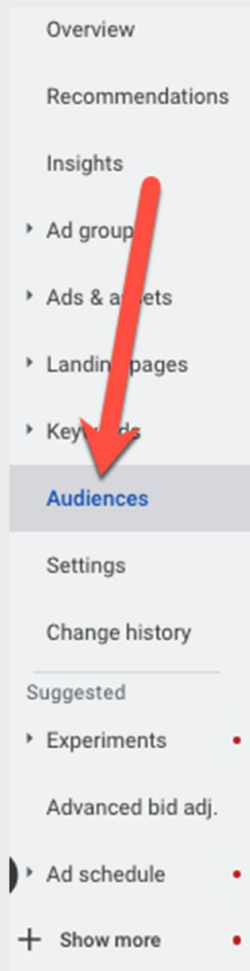
Google Ads interface showing audience segments. A red arrow points from the 'Add filter' button to the 'Campaign view' dropdown menu.

Audience segment	Type	Targeting setting	Ad groups	Clicks
Home & Garden	In-market segment	Observation	0 ad groups	12,184
[Engagement] Visited last 360 days	Website visitors	Observation	0 ad groups	2,252
[Engagement] Visited last 14 days	Website visitors	Observation	0 ad groups	596
Similar to [Engagement] Visited last 360 days	Similar segment	Observation	0 ad groups	275
Apparel & Accessories	In-market segment	Observation	0 ad groups	246
Similar to 20200114_AllEmailSubscribers	Similar segment	Observation	0 ad groups	233
Shoppers	Affinity segment	Observation	0 ad groups	211
Media & Entertainment	Affinity segment	Observation	0 ad groups	184
Media & Entertainment Book Lovers	Affinity segment	Observation	0 ad groups	161
Lifestyles & Hobbies	Affinity segment	Observation	0 ad groups	151

HOW TO USE AN EXPERIMENT WITH THEM

Create your Experiment, and duplicate the Campaign you want to test the Audience filtering on.

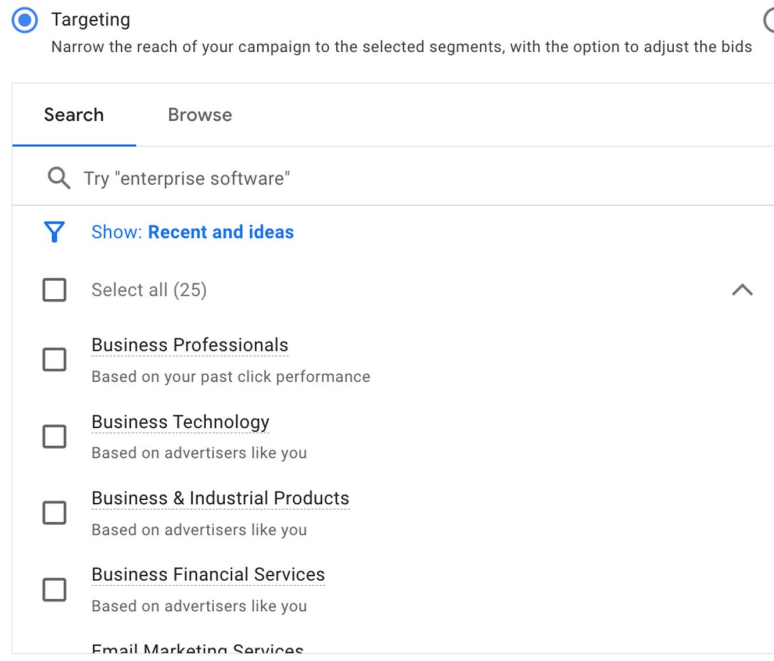
Navigate Experiment Campaigns → Audiences.



TESTING AUDIENCES

Choose the Audiences you want to target.

This will ensure you are only showing your Experiment to users in those Audiences when they search.



WHAT TO LEARN

1. What is CPA/ROAS like when you filter this way?
2. Do you sacrifice volume, or does it seem most of your results still skew towards these Audiences?
3. If you aren't running Broad match in your existing Campaign, you may not want to add that match type in your Experiment to see if you gain more volume and/or efficiency in cost.

LESSON RECAP

1. Running an Experiment to test slimming down your ads to only Audiences you choose can be a great way to see if it's more efficient.
2. You can also add Broad match versions of your keywords to the Experiment to understand if it helps increase conversion volume, and/or reduce costs further versus your current setup.

Lesson 7:

Performance Max

Experiments

Course Objective 3: Setting Up and Using Performance Max Experiments

LESSON OBJECTIVES

1. Quick overview of the new Performance Max Experiment types.
2. What can you test and how to run it.

QUICK REVIEW OF PERFORMANCE MAX

- Give Google Shopping feed, ad copy assets, goal type, and audience signal.
- It will create and run ads on all its property types to try and reach goal.
 - Search
 - Shopping
 - Display
 - Gmail Ads
 - Discovery
 - YouTube
- You cannot exclude properties, or control much of anything.

EXPERIMENT TYPES

There are two ways to test Performance Max in Google Ads.

Unlike other Experiments where you're testing various aspects, these don't do that.

They basically help you see PMax performance versus more traditional Google Ads setups.

EXPERIMENT TYPES

Type #1: Test Uplift from PMax

See if there's an overall impact to whole account results by running PMax alongside your current setup.

Type #2: Test versus Standard Shopping

See if PMax outperforms a traditional Shopping setup.

Note: Smart Shopping was sunset in favor of PMax.

You don't have any experiments yet



Test uplift from Performance Max



Test vs. Shopping campaign

TESTING UPLIFT

You still follow the same steps to create a Custom Experiment we reviewed in the previous lesson.

Select a campaign to test uplift from Performance Max
Understand the impact of running Performance Max alongside your existing campaigns.

Performance Max (treatment)

Create or select a Performance Max campaign to test

[Select campaign](#) [Create new](#)

 Campaigns with a linked Merchant Center account are not supported

TESTING UPLIFT

You still follow the same steps to create a Custom Experiment we reviewed in the previous lesson.

Select a campaign to test uplift from Performance Max

Understand the impact of running Performance Max alongside your existing campaigns.

Performance Max (treatment)

Create or select a Performance Max campaign to test

[Select campaign](#)

[Create new](#)



Campaigns with a linked Merchant Center account are not supported

TESTING UPLIFT

What does it actually show us?

Ultimately, if you can see an overall uplift in account performance and volume by adding Performance Max.

50% split only, and shows eligible campaigns + PMax results versus current campaigns.

Select a campaign to test uplift from Performance Max

Understand the impact of running Performance Max alongside your existing campaigns.

Performance Max (treatment)

● PMax_NoShopping

Budget	\$200.00/day
Domain	
Goals	Purchases (website)
Locations	United States
Languages	English
Bid strategy	Maximize conversion value



Due to the traffic split, your Performance Max campaign may see up to 50% less traffic when included in an experiment.

Select an ex
Max campa
before start

TESTING UPLIFT

May 5 – 21, 2023 ▾			
Experiment campaigns	Conv. value	ROAS	Cost
Control group 2 comparable campaigns	16,316.99	550.65%	\$2,963.24
Treatment group Comparable + Performance Max campaign	21,612.36	344.77%	\$6,268.62
Difference ⓘ	+5,295.37	-205.88%	+\$3,305.38
⤴ Difference (%) ⓘ	+32%	-37%	+112%
95% confidence interval ⓘ	[-23% , +88%] Not statistically significant	[-64% , -11%] Statistically significant	[+92% , +131%] Statistically significant

**Testing Uplift is useful,
but the nature of
Performance Max
makes this very “all or
nothing” decision.**

IS UPLIFT USEFUL?

Possibly, but the black box nature of Performance Max makes this very “all or nothing” decision.

It is good to help you understand the overall impact adding PMax would have, and also which Campaigns it would affect, enhance, or detract from the most.

TESTING PMAX VS. SHOPPING

The other PMax Experiment type shows you results of running Performance Max versus only running standard Shopping.

Select campaigns to test Performance Max vs. Shopping campaign
Understand how Performance Max compares to your Standard Shopping campaign.

Standard Shopping campaign (control)

Select a Standard Shopping campaign that is not in a current experiment

[Select campaign](#)

Experiment results will be evaluated against this selected Shopping campaign

TESTING PMAX VS. SHOPPING

Select campaigns to test Performance Max vs. Shopping campaign

Understand how Performance Max compares to your Standard Shopping campaign.

Standard Shopping campaign (control)

● Shopping_US_Singles

Budget	\$400.00/day
Merchant	
Bid strategy	Target ROAS
Target ROAS	150%
Goals	Account default goals: Downloads (mobile app) +2 more

Experiment results will be evaluated against this selected Shopping campaign

i The selected shopping campaign has inventory filters and product group subdivisions. Please create equivalent listing groups in the Performance Max campaign for proper performance evaluation.

Traffic split

50% ▼

Treatment group
50%

Control group
50%

Up to 50% of the traffic will be diverted to the Performance Max campaign and up to 50% of the traffic will continue to serve existing campaigns

Performance Max (treatment)

Create or select a Performance Max campaign to test

[Create new](#) [Select campaign](#)

Create a new Performance Max campaign or select an existing one before starting the experiment.

Settings like budget, bidding, goals, targeting, etc. are by default based on the control campaign if you create a new Performance Max campaign.

i Campaigns need to have been linked with the same Merchant Center account [redacted] as the selected Shopping campaign Shopping_US_ [redacted]

TESTING PMAX VS. SHOPPING

Remember that PMax will run you on more than just Shopping.

If you want to get a better idea of PMax as solely a Shopping mechanism, you can always create a PMax campaign with only a Merchant Center feed, and provide no additional assets that would allow it to run on its other properties.

LESSON RECAP

1. Performance Max Experiments only offer two things to test:
 - a. Overall account performance when PMax is added
 - b. How PMax does versus standard Shopping
2. Uplift: How does it affect your existing campaigns? How does it affect brand search campaigns?
3. Shopping: Does it deliver better utilizing all of Google's properties versus trying to manually control things only on Search?

Course Wrap-Up:

Recap

COURSE RECAP

1. Experiments are a great way to run a controlled test to determine future changes you're considering in your search campaigns.
2. Ad variations help you test more specific things in the current RSA-led environment, but you may find they don't move the needle much aside from testing URL.
3. I always recommend testing:
 - a. Bidding
 - b. Audiences
4. Performance Max really only lets you test its effectiveness versus more traditional setups. It doesn't give you all the features and nuances that exist within the Custom Experiment features.
5. If you like what you see in the Experiment, you can hit "Apply" and it will automatically convert the Campaign to the new setup.

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